

REPENTANCE

Dead Cells-esque Overworld Map Prototype

Purpose: A logical, nuanced, game-ready scaffold for an overworld built around return, failure, grace, resistance, surrender, and refusing despair.

This document prioritizes structure over final art direction. It is meant to be used as a map handoff, prototype reference, or level-design scaffold.

Core loop:
Failure -> Return -> Fight again -> Learn -> Go deeper -> Fall again -> Be restored again

Every run starts at The Place of Return, where the player is restored by grace, then chooses a route through different forms of resistance. The goal is not simply to escape. The goal is to reach The Mercy Seat.

Map Symbol	Meaning
[HUB]	Safe return point, upgrades, NPCs, unlocked shortcuts.
[BIO]	Main combat biome with a distinct emotional and mechanical identity.
[MID]	Transition node, shop, rest space, lore room, or choice point.
[ALT]	Optional harder route with stronger rewards or secret progression.
[BOS]	Boss arena.
[LOCK]	Ability, story key, or previous run unlock required.
[SC]	Permanent shortcut unlocked after progress.
[END]	Final destination or ending node.

1. Core World Concept

The world is called The Inward Wilderness. It is not literally inside someone's mind, but it represents the internal and external journey of repentance. The player is walking through the consequences, distortions, wounds, and lies that resist return.

The main goal is The Mercy Seat. The final enemy is not a generic monster or a cartoon version of sin. The final enemy is the voice that says, 'You already failed. Stay down. Stay dead.'

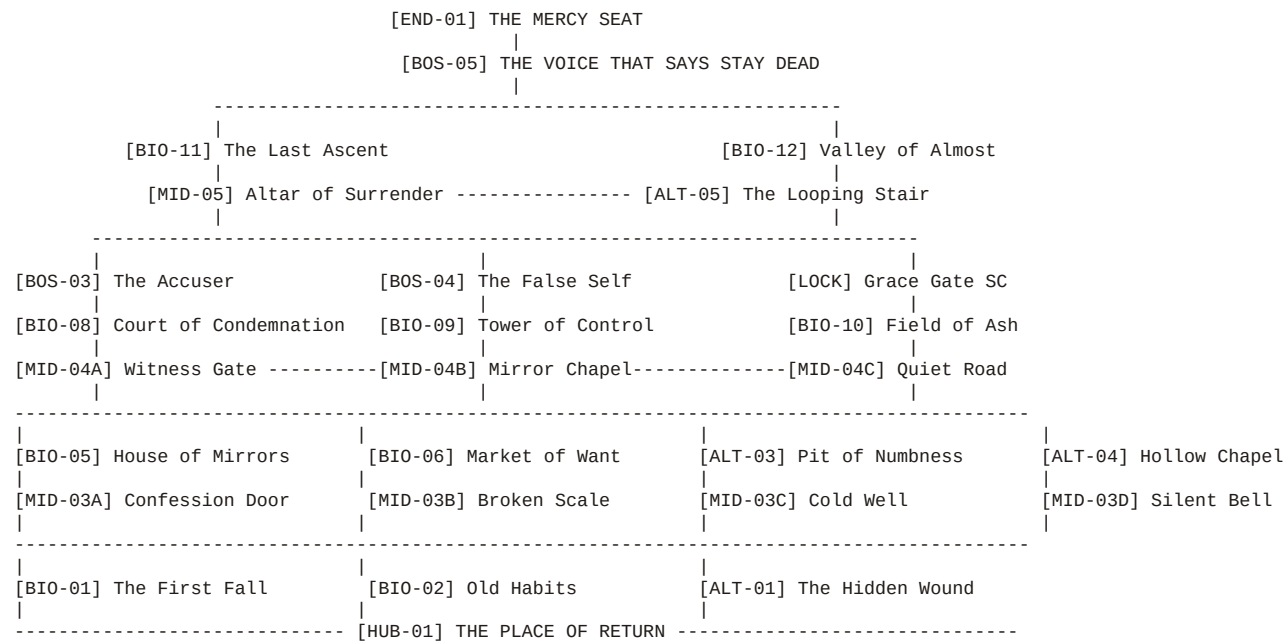
Design principle: The player does not respawn because they are strong. The player respawns because grace refuses to let the story end there.

Layer of Resistance	What It Represents	Primary Map Expression
Shame	Believing you are your failure.	The First Fall -> House of Mirrors -> Court of Condemnation -> The Accuser
Desire	Wanting good things in disordered ways.	Old Habits -> Market of Want -> Tower of Control -> The False Self
Hidden Wound	Pain underneath destructive behavior.	Hidden Wound -> Pit of Numbness -> Hollow Chapel -> Field of Ash
Surrender	Letting go instead of controlling the story.	Altar of Surrender -> Last Ascent
Despair	The temptation to stop returning.	Valley of Almost -> The Voice That Says Stay Dead

Lower World = falling, habit, buried pain
Middle World = distorted identity, want, numbness, performance
Upper World = accusation, control, consequence
Final World = surrender, ascent, almost-return, mercy

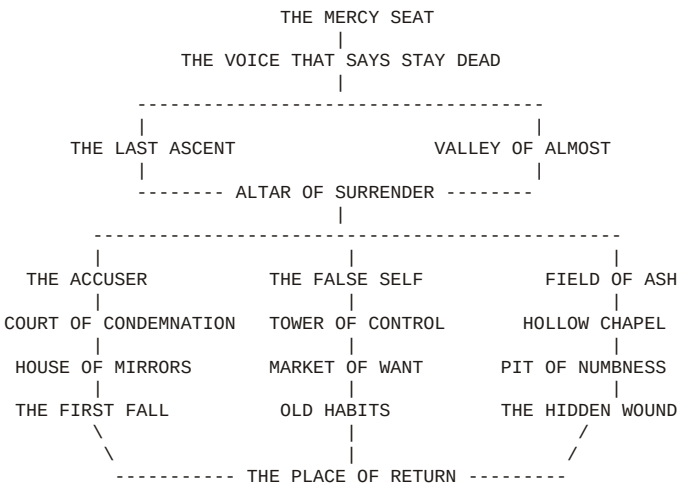
2. Full Overworld Scaffold

This is the larger map structure. It gives the designer enough route logic to build Dead Cells-style branching while keeping the world geographically and emotionally coherent.



3. Clean Base Map

This is the strongest simplified version. It is the best version to use for early implementation, a whitebox prototype, or a node-selection overworld screen.



Implementation note: Build this version first. Add optional cross-connections, keys, secret branches, and shortcuts only after the core route logic feels clean.

4. Hub and Early Game

[HUB-01] The Place of Return

The respawn hub. This is the theological and mechanical center of the game. It contains upgrades, weapon selection, NPC encouragement, repentance records, unlocked shortcuts, and the light beam where the player reappears after death.

- Purpose:
- player resurrects here after death
 - upgrade station
 - weapon selection
 - NPC encouragement
 - repentance records
 - unlocked shortcuts

- Visual logic:
- small camp
 - broken altar
 - warm light
 - old banners
 - quiet music
 - light beam where player appears

[BIO-01] The First Fall

The standard opening biome. It represents the moment of collapse. It should be readable, fair, and emotionally clear.

Category	Design
Theme	The moment of collapse.
Mechanics	Basic enemies, cracked ground, simple traps, early branching rooms, tutorialized combat pressure.
Enemy ideas	Impulse Runners, Regret Crawlers, Shame Sparks, Hollow Strikers.
Exits	House of Mirrors, Market of Want, Hidden Wound if Broken Memory is unlocked.

[BIO-02] Old Habits

An alternate first biome about patterns the player keeps returning to. It teaches that repentance is not just feeling bad. Repentance is a changed direction.

Category	Design
Theme	Repeated behavior, familiar compromise, recurring patterns.
Mechanics	Looping rooms, enemies respawn in certain zones, repeated trap patterns, doors that lead back unless the player breaks a chain or objective.
Exits	Market of Want, Pit of Numbness.

[ALT-01] The Hidden Wound

A locked early route about the pain underneath the behavior. It is quieter, harder, and more revealing than the standard routes.

Category	Design
Requirement	Broken Memory.
Theme	Buried pain, avoidance, grief, quiet bitterness.
Mechanics	Fewer enemies, harder elites, hidden lore rooms, permanent shortcut fragments.
Exits	House of Mirrors, Pit of Numbness.

5. Major Route 1 - Shame Route

[HUB-01] The Place of Return
|
[BIO-01] The First Fall
|
[BIO-05] House of Mirrors
|
[BIO-08] Court of Condemnation
|
[BOS-03] The Accuser

This route deals with shame, self-hatred, regret, identity distortion, and believing you are your failure. It should feel heavy, but not hopeless.

Node	Core Idea	Gameplay Function
House of Mirrors	Distorted identity.	Mirror enemies, fake treasure rooms, reflected platforms, enemies that mimic attacks.
Witness Gate	Learning to stand against accusation.	Reduces shame/curse effects and unlocks accusation-resistant doors.
Court of Condemnation	Judgment without mercy.	Courtroom layout, enemy witnesses, accusation projectiles, chains, verdict modifiers.
The Accuser	The voice that weaponizes failure.	Summons previous killers, creates guilt zones, weakens when the player keeps moving forward.

Boss reward: Witness Mark. This unlocks late-game accusation doors and affirms that the player is no longer defined only by failure.

6. Major Route 2 - Desire Route

[HUB-01] The Place of Return
|
[BIO-02] Old Habits
|
[BIO-06] Market of Want
|
[BIO-09] Tower of Control
|
[BOS-04] The False Self

This route is about appetite, greed, lust, control, comfort, comparison, and false identity. It does not treat desire itself as evil. It shows desire becoming disordered.

Node	Core Idea	Gameplay Function
Market of Want	Disordered desire.	High rewards, cursed items, enemy merchants, greed traps, optional rooms with severe consequences.
Mirror Chapel	Power versus surrender.	The player can take power with a curse, or surrender power for a grace capacity upgrade.
Tower of Control	Pride, image, self-salvation.	Vertical tower, precise platforming, locked levers, shield enemies, rooms that temporarily remove control.

Node	Core Idea	Gameplay Function
The False Self	Identity built on control and performance.	Copies the player's build, counters repeated patterns, weakens when the player changes rhythm.

Boss reward: Surrender Seal. This unlocks the Altar of Surrender and the deeper endgame path.

7. Major Route 3 - Hidden Wound Route

[HUB-01] The Place of Return
|
[ALT-01] The Hidden Wound
|
[ALT-03] Pit of Numbness
|
[ALT-04] Hollow Chapel
|
[BIO-10] Field of Ash

This route deals with buried pain, avoidance, numbness, spiritual exhaustion, unprocessed grief, and quiet bitterness. It should not feel edgy. It should feel quiet, cold, and dangerous.

Node	Core Idea	Gameplay Function
Pit of Numbness	Not caring anymore.	Muted music, fog of war, slower enemy reveals, fewer resources, attacks that drain color/light.
Hollow Chapel	Religion without surrender.	Ritual enemies buff others, safe-looking rooms become traps, confession booths heal or ambush based on choices.
Field of Ash	Consequences, not final punishment.	Burned fields, slow enemies, ash storms, limited visibility, remnants from earlier biomes.

Nuance: Hollow Chapel should not communicate 'church bad.' It represents spiritual performance without actual repentance.

8. Late Game and Final Sequence

[MID-05] Altar of Surrender

The final decision point before the endgame. The player must give up one temporary advantage to continue. This keeps the theme from becoming 'repentance means getting stronger' and makes it feel like surrender.

Requirements:

- Witness Mark OR Surrender Seal

Possible surrender costs:

- lose one weapon
- lose one mutation
- surrender bonus gold
- give up a cursed relic

Reward:

- Grace Burst fully charges
- final route unlocks

[BIO-11] The Last Ascent

A vertical late-game climb about obedience after repentance. The player has returned, but still has to walk forward.

Mechanics:

- vertical climb
- enemies from all previous routes
- fewer shops
- harder platforming
- no easy escape rooms

[BIO-12] Valley of Almost

An optional late-game route about almost repenting, almost changing, and almost surrendering. It represents the danger of getting close to transformation but refusing the final surrender.

Mechanics:

- fake exits
- almost-completed bridges
- enemies that flee and return stronger
- doors that open only if the player has surrendered something

Reward:

- secret ending fragments
- rare grace upgrades

Risk:

- longer route
- harder enemies
- more despair effects

[BOS-05] The Voice That Says Stay Dead

The final boss is the temptation to stop returning. It is the voice that says the player's failure is the end of the story.

Phase 1: Replays your deaths
- summons echoes of previous failed runs

Phase 2: Corrupts the respawn beam
- disables Grace Burst temporarily

Phase 3: The Lie
- arena darkens
- boss becomes invisible unless the player moves toward light sources

Phase 4: Return
- Grace Burst comes back stronger
- player must keep advancing instead of retreating

Victory meaning: The player does not become perfect. The loop of despair is broken. The player can still return, but now they return with hope instead of shame.

9. Game Logic Node List

This node list is formatted so it can be adapted into a spreadsheet, Godot data file, JSON map, or whitebox prototype.

```
HUB-01: The Place of Return
connects_to:
- BIO-01
- BIO-02
- ALT-01 [LOCK: Broken Memory]
```

```
BIO-01: The First Fall
connects_to:
- BIO-05
- BIO-06
- ALT-01 [LOCK: Broken Memory]
```

```
BIO-02: Old Habits
connects_to:
- BIO-06
- ALT-03
```

```
ALT-01: The Hidden Wound
connects_to:
- BIO-05
- ALT-03
```

```
BIO-05: House of Mirrors
connects_to:
- MID-04A
- BIO-08
```

```
BIO-06: Market of Want
connects_to:
- MID-04B
- BIO-09
```

```
ALT-03: Pit of Numbness
connects_to:
- ALT-04
- BIO-10
```

```
ALT-04: Hollow Chapel
connects_to:
- BIO-10
- BOS-03
```

```
BIO-08: Court of Condemnation
connects_to:
- BOS-03
```

```
BIO-09: Tower of Control
connects_to:
- BOS-04
```

```
BOS-03: The Accuser
connects_to:
- MID-05
unlocks:
- Witness Mark
- SC-02
```

BOS-04: The False Self
connects_to:
- MID-05
unlocks:
- Surrender Seal
- SC-03

BIO-10: Field of Ash
connects_to:
- MID-05
- BIO-12

MID-05: Altar of Surrender
requires:
- Witness Mark OR Surrender Seal
connects_to:
- BIO-11
- BIO-12

BIO-11: The Last Ascent
connects_to:
- BOS-05

BIO-12: Valley of Almost
connects_to:
- BOS-05
- ALT-05

ALT-05: The Looping Stair
requires:
- Quiet Flame
connects_to:
- secret ending path

BOS-05: The Voice That Says Stay Dead
connects_to:
- END-01

END-01: The Mercy Seat
connects_to:
- endings

10. Permanent Shortcuts and Ability Gates

Shortcut	Unlock	Effect
SC-01 Old Habits Shortcut	Clear Old Habits 3 times.	Hub can start directly at Market of Want.
SC-02 Witness Gate Shortcut	Defeat The Accuser.	Skip House of Mirrors and enter Court of Condemnation directly.
SC-03 Grace Gate	Defeat The False Self.	Access Altar of Surrender earlier.
SC-04 Wound Door	Find Broken Memory.	Access Hidden Wound from the hub.
SC-05 Mercy Path	Beat the final boss once.	Unlock higher-difficulty repentance cycles.

Gate / Key	Unlocks	Meaning
Broken Memory	Hidden Wound.	The player is willing to face what they buried.
Witness Mark	Accusation-resistant doors.	The player is no longer defined only by failure.
Surrender Seal	Altar of Surrender.	The player has stopped trying to save themselves by control.
Grace Burst	High vertical routes and final combat recovery.	Grace gives movement, not just forgiveness.
Quiet Flame	Pit of Numbness secrets.	Hope still exists even when feelings are gone.

Best next build step: Implement the clean base map first with placeholder rooms. Each biome only needs one visual block, one enemy family, one mechanical twist, one exit rule, and one reward rule. Once that works, add optional branches and shortcuts.

11. Overworld Screen Layering

If this becomes a visual overworld screen, separate the map into clear layers. This makes it easier to create, animate, and revise later.

Layer 1 - Background silhouette
- dark wilderness, broken path, far mountain or temple shape
- not interactive

Layer 2 - Region shapes
- lower wilderness and ruins
- middle mirrors / market / numb pit
- upper court / tower / ash field
- final ascent and mercy seat

Layer 3 - Route lines
- normal paths = solid lines
- locked paths = dashed lines
- shortcuts = bright thick lines
- secret paths = faint or dim lines

Layer 4 - Node icons
- hub flame / altar icon
- biome icons
- boss icons
- lock icons
- shortcut icons

Layer 5 - Labels
- readable area names
- required key markers
- difficulty or route identity markers

Core handoff sentence: The player is not merely climbing toward a final boss. They are moving from falling, to facing, to surrendering, to returning, to refusing despair.